

FROM LAND TO SEA

Fifty million years ago (MYA) the ancestors of whales were not swimming in seas but living on land and walking on four legs. These animals gradually started spending more time feeding in water. Slowly, their bodies changed and whales eventually left dry land forever.

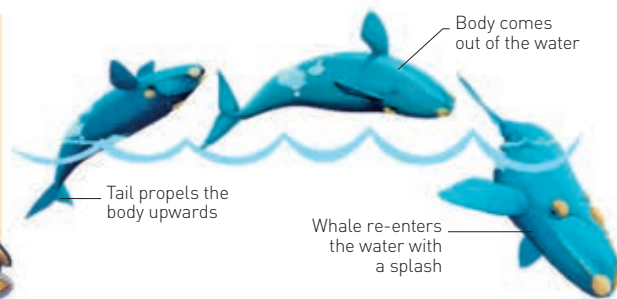


1 PAKICETUS (50 MYA)
About the size of a large dog, this animal sometimes swam after fish. Its fossilized ear bones match those of modern whales.

2 DORUDON (38 MYA)
Able to swim well, this early whale had front flippers, tiny hindlimbs, and a flexible tail. The nostrils had shifted to the top of the head as blowholes.

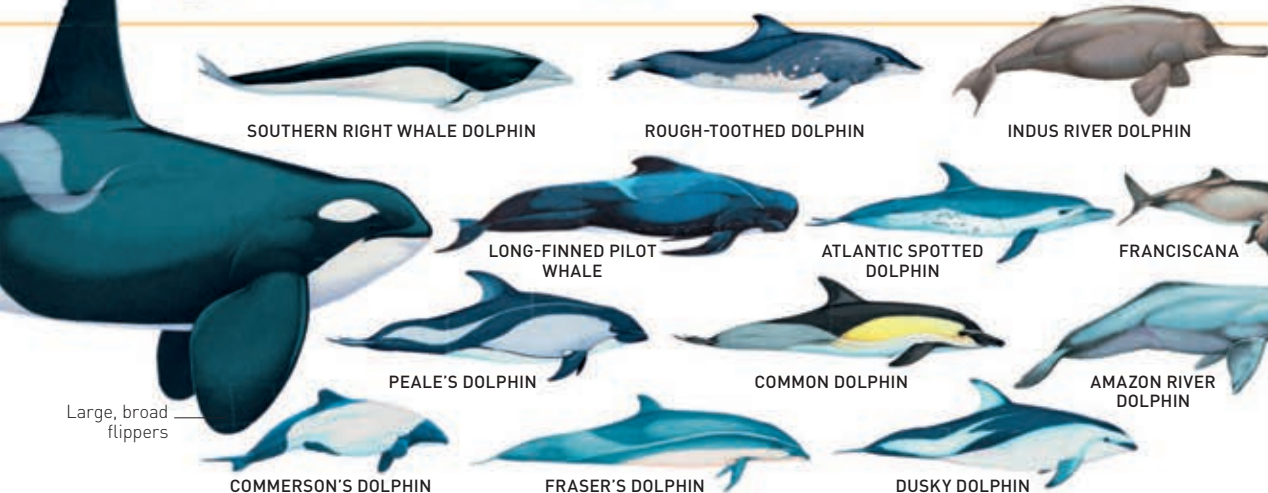
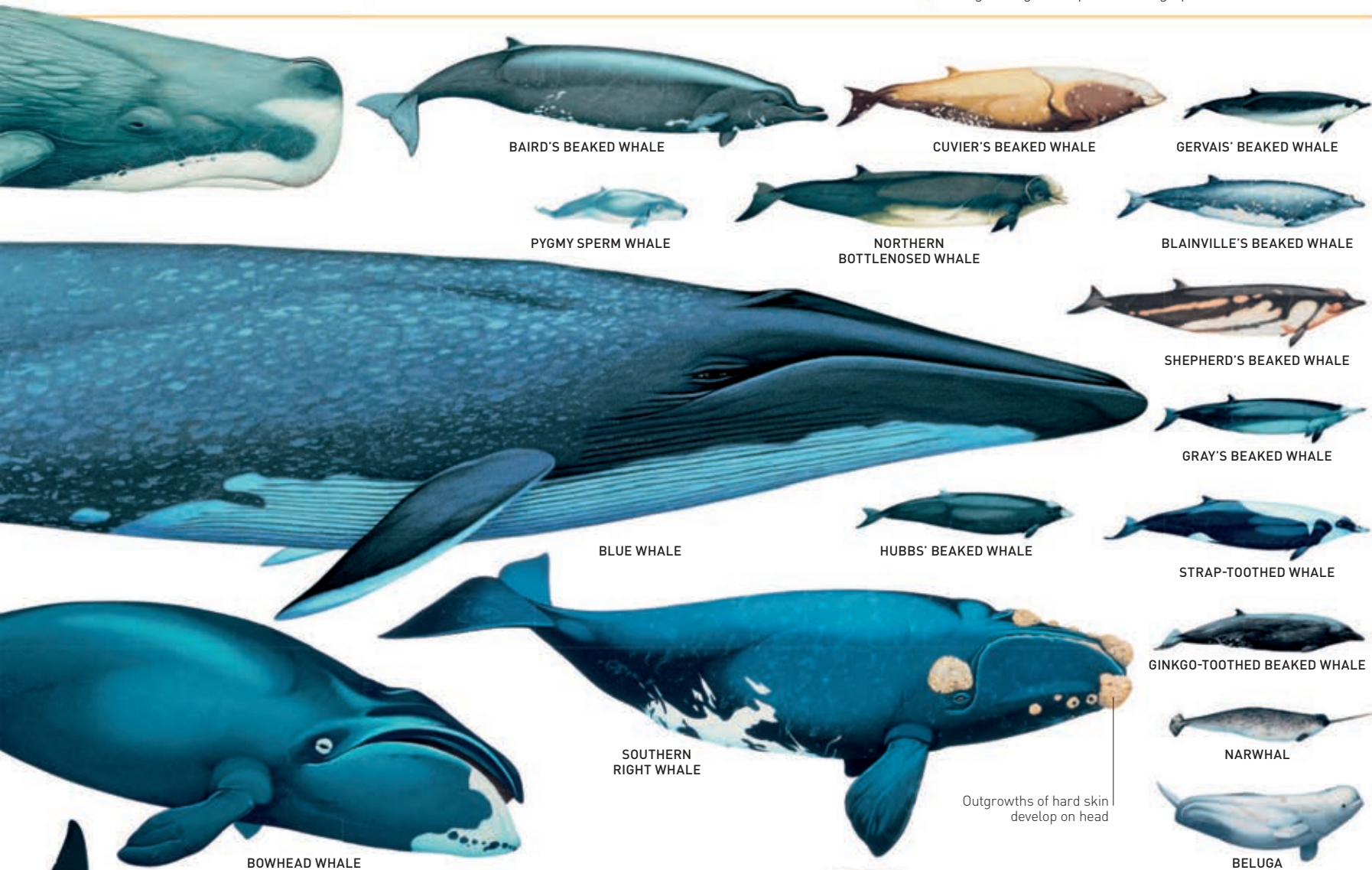
3 MODERN WHALE
Perfectly adapted for ocean life, the whale has a streamlined body, powerful flippers, and a flat tail to aid propulsion. The hindlegs have vanished.

THE BLUE WHALE CAN MEASURE UP TO 30.5 M (100 FT) LONG



BREACHING

Whales often leap high out of the water and plunge back with a large splash. This is called breaching, and scientists are not sure why whales do it. Possibly it is a form of signalling or helps to dislodge parasites.



PORPOISES

Most of this group are smaller and rounder-bodied than their relatives. Porpoises are usually found in shallow seas near the coast.

